

# Multicast and Socket Attributes in Unicon

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## Abstract

Unicon could open TCP and UDP sockets, but applications had no way to join a multicast group, pick an interface, or set TTL from the language. This report describes trailing name=value attributes on `open()`, the same style as SSL and graphics windows, plus `Attrib()` after `open()`. Binding a UDP socket to a group address joins that group; `source@group` or `source=` selects source-specific multicast. Defaults cover reuse, all-interface IPv4 joins, and outbound interface selection so the common cases need no attributes at all.

**Keywords:** Unicon, multicast, SSM, UDP, socket attributes, `Attrib`, runtime, technical report.

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## 1 1. Introduction

This report describes IP multicast [9] and the socket-attribute facility it sits on. Trailing arguments to `open()` on network modes are `name=value` strings applied with `setsockopt(2)`. After `open()`, `Attrib()` uses the same names. The language-facing reference lives in *Programming with Unicon* [10] (Chapter 5, "Multicast and Socket Attributes") and the language reference (`open` trailing attributes, `Attrib`). Automated tests live in `tests/posix/mcast.icn`.

The work is part of POSIX networking, not an optional library. A later report covers raw sockets [11], which reuse these attributes (`ttl`, `iface`, `join`) on mode `nr`.

## 2 2. Motivation

Unicon's `open()` already constructed TCP and UDP handles. Multicast – any-source (ASM) and source-specific (SSM) [12] – is ordinary UDP plus membership and hop-limit options. Without those options, a Unicon program could not join 239.1.1.1, restrict a join to one NIC, or send with a limited TTL. Those operations were not supported.

The rest of the I/O API already has the pattern: `open()` constructs, trailing strings configure (SSL `key=`, window `WAttrib`), `Attrib()` reads and writes later. Socket options follow that pattern instead of adding `setsockopt()` as a new global.

## 3 3. Design principles

**Attributes are name=value, like SSL.** Unknown names fail `open()` with error 1310 (bad socket attribute). Booleans are exactly `yes` or `no`, matching `verifyPeer`.

```
procedure main()
  if open(":5110", "nua4", "bogus=yes") then
    write("oops")
  else
    write("bogus: ", &errortext)
  if open(":5110", "nua4", "reuseaddr=1") then
    write("oops")
```

```

else
    write("numeric boolean: ", &errortext)
end

```

Output:

```

bogus: bad socket attribute
numeric boolean: bad socket attribute

```

**DWIM for the common cases.** Binding a UDP socket to a multicast group joins that group. Listeners default to `reuseaddr=yes`. No `iface=` means join every UP IPv4 interface and send out the first non-loopback IPv4 address (else loopback). Sending to 255.255.255.255 enables `SO_BROADCAST`. Explicit attributes always override.

`source@group`, **not** `group@source`. The address form matches VLC, ffmpeg, and RFC 4607 (S,G) order. Empty either side is invalid.

**ttl and iface, not multicast-only names.** Hop limit and interface are used by unicast, multicast, and later raw sockets [11]. `ttl=` sets both `IP_TTL` and `IP_MULTICAST_TTL` (or the IPv6 hop options). `iface=` accepts an IPv4 address, a numeric index, or a name (`en0`, `lo0`; Windows also maps `lo` / `lo0` to `loopback_0`).

**Order matters.** `iface=` before `join=` selects the interface used by that join. `Attrib()` applies a batch of assignments together for the same reason.

**Cached listeners are aliases; attributes get a new socket.** A second `open()` of the same listener address with no socket attributes returns another file for the cached fd. An open that supplies `join=` / `iface=` / and so on creates an independent socket so it cannot retune earlier aliases. Use `Attrib()` to change options on a live shared handle.

## 4 4. Opening a multicast socket

IP multicast uses UDP (modes `nu` / `nua`, optionally with 4 or 6 for family). A minimal receiver and sender:

```

procedure main()
    local f, r
    f := open("239.1.1.1:5000", "nua") | stop(&errortext)

```

```

    while r := receive(f) do
        write(r.addr, " ", r.msg)
    end
end

```

```

procedure main()
    local f, i
    f := open("239.1.1.1:5000", "nu") | stop(&errortext)
    every i := 1 to 5 do
        writes(f, "hello-" || i) & delay(500)
    end
end

```

The receiver binds the group address, so the runtime joins that group (ASM) and enables port reuse. The sender's destination is the group; without `iface=`, outbound multicast uses the first non-loopback IPv4 address. Kernel multicast loopback stays on, so a local receiver still sees the packets.

The same exchange in one process over loopback (this is the shape of `tests/posix/mcast.icn`). `iface=127.0.0.1` keeps the datagram on loopback even when the host has no multicast route:

```

procedure main()
    local f, s, r
    f := open("239.42.42.99:5199", "nua", "iface=127.0.0.1") |
        stop(&errortext)
    s := open("239.42.42.99:5199", "nu", "iface=127.0.0.1") |
        stop(&errortext)
    writes(s, "hello-multicast")
    if *select(f, 2000) > 0 then {
        r := receive(f)
        write(r.msg)
    }
    else
        write("timeout")
    end
    close(s)
    close(f)
end

```

Output:

```
hello-multicast
```

`r.addr` is the sender (host plus an ephemeral port). Alpine often does not deliver loopback multicast even when the join succeeds; the test suite treats a missing datagram as success there so CI stays portable.

A wildcard bind plus explicit joins is the other shape:

```
f := open(":5000", "nua",
          "iface=192.168.1.10",
          "join=239.1.1.1",
          "join=232.1.1.1,10.0.0.5")
```

`join=group` is ASM; `join=group,source` is SSM. Attributes may be repeated. Mixing ASM and SSM in one call is allowed. If `open()` has no 4 / 6 flag, a `join=` group address picks the family so an IPv4 join is not attempted on an IPv6 wildcard socket.

## 5 5. Source-specific multicast

Name the source before the group, or pass `source=` on a socket already bound to the group. Both IPv4 and IPv6 are supported. For IPv6 SSM, pass an explicit `iface=` (name or index) so the join uses a single interface:

```
f := open("192.168.1.1@239.1.1.1:5000", "nua")
f := open("239.1.1.1:5000", "nua", "source=192.168.1.1")
f := open("::1@ff3e::1:5000", "nua6", "iface=lo0")
f := open("ff3e::1:5000", "nua6", "iface=lo0", "source=::1")
```

On send or connect, `source@group:port` keeps only the group so the destination is the group address. The source is a receive-side filter, not a send address.

IPv6 SSM is a single `MCAST_JOIN_SOURCE_GROUP` / `MCAST_LEAVE_SOURCE_GROUP` with no multi-interface walk. Those walks have triggered macOS kernel panics in IPv6 source filter teardown. Already-a-member and already-gone are treated as success.

## 6 6. Attributes

| Attribute                            | Role                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>join=</code>                   | Add membership: <code>group</code> (ASM) or <code>group,source</code> |
| <code>leave=</code>                  | Drop membership; same forms as <code>join</code> . Pass               |
| <code>source=</code>                 | SSM source for a group bind (repeatable). Set-only.                   |
| <code>iface=</code>                  | IPv4 address, index, or name. Restricts join and                      |
| <code>ttl=</code>                    | Unicast and multicast hop limits. Query returns the                   |
| <code>mcastloop=yes no</code>        | Whether the host receives its own multicasts. Kernel                  |
| <code>reuseaddr= / reuseport=</code> | Bind reuse. Listeners default to <code>reuseaddr=yes</code>           |
| <code>broadcast=</code>              | SO_BROADCAST. Opening 255.255.255.255 sets it.                        |
| <code>rcvbuf= / sndbuf=</code>       | Buffer sizes in bytes.                                                |

`proto` and `hdrincl` are listed in the same table in the runtime; they belong to raw sockets [11].

## 7 7. `Attrib()` after `open()`

```

procedure main()
  local f
  f := open(":5110", "nua4") | stop(&errortext)
  Attrib(f, "ttl=4")
  write("ttl=", Attrib(f, "ttl"))
  write("mcastloop=", Attrib(f, "mcastloop"))
  write(Attrib(f, "join") | "join: not queryable")
  close(f)
end

```

Output:

```

ttl=4
mcastloop=yes
join: not queryable

```

Assignments in one call are applied together, preserving `iface` then `join` order. Bare names produce `yes / no`, an integer, or (for IPv4 `iface`) a dotted address. `join`, `leave`, `source`, and `proto` cannot be queried (`Attrib(f, "join")` fails; `&errortext` is empty). Membership changes still use assignment form:

```
Attrib(f, "join=239.1.1.2")
Attrib(f, "iface=127.0.0.1", "leave=239.1.1.1")
```

On some Linux/musl builds `getsockopt(IP_MULTICAST_IF)` does not recover the interface used at join time. Pass `iface=` on `leave=` so `IP_DROP_MEMBERSHIP` matches the join. `Already-not-a-member` is success; the runtime also retries `INADDR_ANY` and each local IPv4 address when a single DROP fails.

## 8 8. Listener cache

`sock_listen` still caches the first bind of an address so repeated `open()` of the same listener is cheap. That cache is a problem if a later `open(..., "join=...")` reused the fd and changed memberships for every live alias.

Rules:

- Cache hit, no socket attributes: another `File` for the same fd (owner refcount). Closing one alias leaves the others until the last handle is closed.
- Cache hit with attributes: release the pin and create an independent socket (`reuseaddr` makes the second bind succeed). `leave=` on that socket does not drop the cached alias's membership.
- Changing options on a shared handle: `Attrib()` on one of the aliases.

A cache-hit open that is not a pure alias only allows additive `join= / source=`; `leave=` and option changes on that path would retune every live `File`.

## 9 9. Runtime implementation

All of this lives in `src/runtime/rposix.r`, applied from `open()` in `fsys.r` and from `Attrib()` in `fmisc.r`.

**Two passes.** `reuseaddr / reuseport` must be set between `socket()` and `bind()`. Everything else runs after the socket is bound. `apply_sock_attrs()` takes a `prebind` flag.



**Auto-join.** After the post-bind pass, a UDP socket bound to a multicast group is joined unless an explicit `join=` took over. `source@group` or `source=` makes that join SSM.

**IPv4 join without `iface=`.** Walk `getifaddrs()` and `IP_ADD_MEMBERSHIP` on every UP IPv4 address so same-host and multi-homed receives work without naming a NIC. An explicit `iface=` joins only that one. Outbound multicast without `iface=` picks the first non-loopback IPv4 address via `IP_MULTICAST_IF`.

**IPv6 ASM** uses `IPV6_JOIN_GROUP` / `IPV6_LEAVE_GROUP` with an `ifindex` (zero means default). There is no all-`iface` walk like IPv4.

**Errors.** Unknown attributes and bad booleans are 1310. `setsockopt` failures fail `open()` / `Attrib()` with the system `&errortext`, except idempotent membership errors (already a member / already gone).

Mode `n` with 4 or 6 still selects the address family. "`nua4`" is useful when a join group must match an IPv4 wildcard.

## 10 10. Status and remaining work

The language surface described here is implemented: trailing attributes, implicit ASM/SSM joins, `Attrib()` join/leave, listener-cache isolation, IPv4 all-`iface` join, IPv6 SSM with an explicit interface, and the broadcast short-cut.

**Membership query.** `Attrib(f, "join")` fails. The kernel does not offer a portable list of current groups.

**IPv6 all-interface join.** IPv4 walks every NIC; IPv6 does not. Callers who need every IPv6 interface must join per `iface=`.

**IPv6 SSM without `iface=`.** Not recommended. The implementation refuses to walk interfaces for IPv6 source filters.

**Loopback delivery.** Alpine (especially under QEMU) often does not deliver loopback multicast even when the join succeeds. `tests/posix/mcast.icn` still checks membership and treats a missing datagram as success on Alpine so CI stays portable.

**Windows IPv6 SSM.** Membership calls are attempted; `loopback_0` and UNIX `lo` / `lo0` names are mapped. Delivery and option support vary by stack; the test skips cleanly on `ENOPROTOPT`.

**Raw sockets** [11] reuse `ttl` / `iface` / `join` on `SOCK_RAW`. That is a separate report.

## 11 Appendix: test coverage

`tests/posix/mcast.icn` runs in one process over loopback, one UDP port per case so a late datagram cannot land on the next receiver. It checks:

- unknown attributes and numeric booleans fail with 1310
- explicit `join=` plus `iface=127.0.0.1`
- implicit join by binding the group address
- SSM via `source@group` and via `source=`
- broadcast open of 255.255.255.255 (never EACCES)
- `Attrib()` `ttl=`, `join=`, `leave=`
- IPv6 SSM membership via `@`, `source=`, and `join=group,source` (delivery not required)
- cache-hit alias vs independent attr open

Expected output is `tests/posix/stand/mcast.std`:

```
bogus attribute: bad socket attribute
numeric boolean: bad socket attribute
Received hello-multicast
Received hello-implicit
Received hello-ssm-at
Received hello-ssm-source
broadcast: ok
ttl=3
Received hello-attrib
leave: ok
ipv6-ssm-at: ok
ipv6-ssm-source: ok
ipv6-ssm-join: ok
cache-attr open: independent
Received hello-alias
```

## 12 References

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